The Golden Door

By Robert Mauro

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *The debate over immigration has existed for many years, but the intensity of the argument both for and against immigrants to the U.S. seems to be consistently increasing.*
ACTRESS 2: *Immigration gives struggling people all over the world an opportunity for a better life. This country was built on immigrants who sought opportunity, political & religious freedom, etc.*
ACTRESS 1: *More immigrants mean more opportunity for terrorists, drug dealers, and other criminals to enter the country.*
ACTRESS 2: *Some of the most intelligent and ambitious individuals, who are unsatisfied with their own countries, bring their skills to America.*
ACTRESS 1: *The national identity and language is disappearing. The great "melting pot" is being replaced by divisive multiculturism.*
ACTRESS 2: *The debate has no easy answers, but one fact remains certain: People from other countries will continue to knock on our Golden Door*
ACTRESS 1: *by Robert Mauro.*

MS. WILSON: **(Pg 147-156)** *(looks over the folder and shakes her head)* Another one. Everyone wants to be a U.S. citizen. They just keep coming and coming and coming. *(Looks offstage)* Next! *(ANNA enters)* Have a sea t. . . So you want to be an American, a U.S. citizen?

ANNA: *(With an accent)* Oh, yes. Yes, I do. Ever since I little girl, I want to be citizen of this wonderful country.

MS. WILSON: Yeah. That's what they all say.

ANNA: It not true? That this is a most wonderful country?

MS. WILSON: *(Ironically)* Oh, it's just great. Terrific.

ANNA: Yes. I know. Most terrific country in the world. One with the great golden door.

MS. WILSON: Golden door? What golden door?

ANNA: *(Surprised that MS. WILSON doesn't know)* You know, the lady's door.

MS. WILSON: Lady? What lady?

ANNA: The big lady. Statue lady.

MS. WILSON: Oh, yeah. You mean the Statue of Liberty.

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ANNA: Yeah. The big lady with the golden door.

MS. WILSON: Well, I don't know about any golden door. If the door was gold, it would have been ripped off by now, or, at the very least, covered with graffiti. There is no golden door.

ANNA: No, no. I have piece of paper that say it golden. *(ANNA looks in her bag and all her pockets for the paper. She finds it in her breast pocket.)* I find it. I keep it safe right by my heart.

MS. WILSON: *(Impatient, ironic)* Wonderful, terrific, but can we get on with this interview? It's been a long day and it's only. . . *(Checks her watch)* Good lord, only 9:25.

ANNA: You don't want to hear about the golden door?

MS. WILSON: It's really not one of the main priorities in my life - unlike getting this interview over with. Do you understand what I'm saying?

ANNA: *(Apologetic)* No. My English. It not too good.

MS. WILSON: So what else is new?

ANNA: *(Pointing to her, very excited)* Oh, I know! I know! **New** York, **New** Jersey, **New** Mexico

MS. WILSON: What?

ANNA: *(laughing)* Yes. Yes. It very funny. A joke. I hear it on boat coming to this great country. You like my joke?

MS. WILSON: *(Very bored)* Can we continue?

ANNA: Yes. So about that golden door. . .

MS. WILSON: Are we still on that?

ANNA: Oh, yes. It very beautiful.

MS. WILSON: Next I'll probably hear the one about the streets being paved with gold.

ANNA: *(Excitedly)* Yes! I hear that, too.

MS. WILSON:I knew it.

ANNA: But it's not true. You have to be very careful where you walk in city street. Many dogs in this city. Many big dogs.

MS. WILSON: You found that out, did you?

ANNA: Yes. But to me streets are still paved with gold. Many jobs! We all work. My brothers, my sisters, my mother, my papa, my whole family. In our country no jobs. Here - **many** jobs.

MS. WILSON: You do have your work permits?

ANNA: Work permit?

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MS. WILSON: Yes. You, as an immigrant, are not allowed to work in this country without a permit. It's the law.

ANNA: But how do we eat or live if we can't work. None of my family is lazy. We all work. It's the American way. No?

MS. WILSON: Look, no permit, no work. Do you understand?

ANNA: No. Do you?

MS. WILSON: *(Getting really annoyed)* It's not my job to understand! My job is to enforce the immigration laws of this country.

ANNA: The land of the free and the home of the brave.

MS. WILSON: Yeah, right. The one in which you need a permit to work.

ANNA: You have one?

MS. WILSON: Do I have what?

ANNA: This work permit.

MS. WILSON: I don't need one. I'm a citizen. You're not.

ANNA: Oh. So where I get this wonderful permit? Through the golden door?

MS. WILSON: Cute. Very cute. Listen, do you know we can deport you for not having a work permit? Do you realize that?

ANNA: But everyone is entitled to life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness in this great country. Right? And to my whole, entire family, work is happiness. Is this not true?

MS. WILSON: Look, I don't know anything about happiness

ANNA: *(Cutting her off, shocked)* You don't? But you so lucky. You are citizen. You have job. You have office that is **your** office. You have much happiness. It is not true?

MS. WILSON: *(Pages through the folder)* Can we get on with this interview? Is that all right with you?

ANNA: I have to tell you about the golden door.

MS. WILSON: I don't have the time. Do you see all these files? *(ANNA nods)* All right. Well, these are just todays. I have a lot of people out there waiting to get in. They all want to be citizens. Do you understand?

ANNA: Oh, yes. They all want to be citizen of this great country. From when we were little children we hear stories about Miss Liberty and life, freedom, the great golden door. Yes. I understand this very well. But do you?

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MS. WILSON: What do you mean, do I? I'm an American, a citizen. Of course, I understand. What makes you think I don't?

ANNA: The way you speak about us. You sound like you don't like us.

MS. WILSON: What ever gave you that idea?

ANNA: You don't speak to me very nice. My name is right there. But you don't say, "Hello, Anna, welcome to our wonderful country where the streets are paved with gold, where there is a wonderful Statue of Liberty that welcomes you, where there is life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. Where there is a golden door. We welcome you, Anna." You don't say **that**, Ms. Wilson. You sound so unhappy. But you should be happy to live where these things exist. They are not everywhere.

MS. WILSON: Look, Anna, it's just that I'm *(a momentary sign of weakness, but she steels herself)* Why am I trying to explain myself to you? Just let me get to the questions I have to ask you.

ANNA: But why don't you answer my question? You like it here?

MS. WILSON: Yes. Where else can I shop in Bloomingdale's, Macy's and Sears - and still not find the right blouse? *(Anna looks confused; she begins to soften)* Look, Anna. . . I don't mean to be rude, but I have a job to do.

ANNA: Yes. You are the doorkeeper.

MS. WILSON: What?

ANNA: Yes. You are the doorkeeper, to the golden door.

MS. WILSON: h, I give up. Will you get it through your head that there is no such thing as a golden door.

ANNA: *(Holding up paper)* But it says so right here. Miss Emma Lazarus says so. America's greatest poet!

MS. WILSON: *(Brushing her aside)* Never mind.

ANNA: Wait, wait. You like her. She wrote this poem.

MS. WILSON: We do not have time for a poetry reading. This is the busiest immigration office in the country.

ANNA: And you don't know who Emma Lazarus is?! *(Does "shame, shame" gesture with her finger)* Shame, shame, Ms. Wilson. You should have big copy of this poem on your door.

MS. WILSON: My door?

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ANNA: Yes. Your door. It is the golden door. No?

MS. WILSON: ell, I never looked at it that way.

ANNA: That's because you are on this side of it. You are inside looking out. We, out there, are outside. We are looking in.

MS. WILSON: Listen, why don't we just begin the interview. OK?

ANNA: You the boss.

MS. WILSON: You sure?

ANNA: You have a big office. All these folders. You must be a boss. No?

MS. WILSON: Me? I am the low man on the totem pole around here.

ANNA: Low man? You not a woman? You a man?!

MS. WILSON: No, I am a woman! "Low man on the totem pole" is just an expression. Like "land of the free and the home of the brave," or "life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness," even "the golden door." They are all just expressions.

ANNA: No, no. They are the truth. You just don't see this.

MS. WILSON: *(Checking her watch)* All I see is that it's getting late and we have to get on with this interview - golden door or no golden door.

ANNA: Funny you should mention golden door. *(Unfolds her poem)*

MS. WILSON: Oh, no. You're not going to give me a poetry reading, are you?

ANNA: If you insist.

MS. WILSON: Oh, please, please. I am all ears.

ANNA: *(Looking at her ears)* No. You have nice little ears.

MS. WILSON: It was just another expression.

ANNA: Oh. You have a lot of them. Don't you? America has much of everything.

MS. WILSON: Especially expressions.

ANNA: You ain't whistling Dixie.

MS. WILSON: *(Pointing at ANNA)* Very good.

ANNA: See. I make a good American. No?

MS. WILSON: I must admit, you do seem to like this country.

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ANNA: No. I love her. And Emma Lazarus. She must have been a wonderful lady. *(ANNA puts on her glasses then reads lovingly.)*

The New Colossus

Not like the brazen giant of Greek fame,
With conquering limb astride from land to land;
Here at our sea-washed, sunset gates shall stand
A mighty woman with a torch, whose flame
Is the imprisoned lightening, and her name
Mother of exiles, from her beacon-hand
Glows world-wide welcome; her mild eyes command
The air-bridged harbor that twin cities frame,
'Keep ancient lands, your storied pomp!' cries she
With silent lips, 'Give me your tired, your poor,
Your huddled masses yearning to breathe free,
The wretched refuse of your teeming shore,
Send these, the homeless, tempest-tost to me,
I lift my lamp beside the golden door!

ANNA: You like?

MS. WILSON: *(moved)* I like very much. In fact, I would like to make a copy of that and hang it on my door.

ANNA: Right. The golden door. *(Offers MS. WILSON the poem)*

MS. WILSON: Yes. *(Takes poem)* I guess we take a lot of this for granted after being here a while.

ANNA: *(proudly)* Not me. *(beat)* So, Ms. Wilson, I make a good citizen?

MS. WILSON: Yes. I'm sure.

ANNA: Ms. Wilson, can I ask you a question?

MS. WILSON: Well, actually, I am supposed to be asking you the questions, Anna, but . . . what the heck, go ahead. Shoot.

ANNA: Shoot?! But I have no gun - *(She sees MS. WILSON smiling)* Oh . . .

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ANNA and MS. WILSON: *(Together)* An expression!

MS. WILSON: Exactly. So what's your question, Anna?

ANNA: The golden door . . . Some people say they are going to put a lock on it. Is this true? *(They look at each other in silence – end scene)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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